All the drinking and the partying and the growing up happens under the same gentle, watchful community support. I smoke two cigarettes and have two pints at the pub, throw up everywhere and have to phone my dad to pick me up from the same place he'd dropped me off an hour earlier. On another occasion, I drink too much and end up in Neil Mortimer's bed when he is out, vomiting in the sheets. I pull them over, don't say a word to anyone, and pretend it didn't happen. Neil is so nice that he doesn't even mention it. I'm sure my parents would have arranged to get those cleaned. I don't ask. Just don't mention it, pretend it hasn't happened, hope it goes away.

We spend our time at Neil's rifling through his record collection, going through CDs and drinking the beers he'd left out for us – always enough to be grateful, to feel like adults, never enough to actually get drunk.

Gaz and I dye our hair for the first time during these years, peroxiding it together in his mum's bathroom. We use plastic bags, making a hole in it and pulling hair through in handfuls to bleach individual clumps. Gaz holds his nerve longer than me, making sure it is left in for long enough. I can feel it burning, singeing its way into my scalp. Panicking and tip-toeing back and forth in the tiny bathroom, I rinse it off. My hair ends up the exact colour and, more strangely, the texture of Big Bird on *Sesame Street*. It doesn't go down well at school, and the next time I see Gaz, I discover that he too had been sent back home and had shaved it all off.

Slightly less painful hair dyeing then ensues at the Mortimers', who also allow us our first trip to see the band James in Manchester. We take the X43 bus, wide-eyed and collectively bracing for a non-Burnley world. I only realise on arrival that I've lost the tickets. We don't have a lot of money, any of us, and spend an hour in a panic outside the MEN Arena in our Marks & Spencers hand-me-down clothes, worrying that our night is over before it has begun. A tout takes pity on us and hands back some tickets on the cheap. We have the night of our lives, singing James songs all the way home.

The first time I go to Old Trafford Cricket Ground is a semi-final one-day game against Yorkshire. The team is full of international cricketers – of superhero-like players, so close you can almost touch them. Wasim Akram, Mike Atherton, Jason Gallian, John Crawley, Neil Fairbrother, Graham Lloyd, Mike Watkinson, Gary Yates, Warren Hegg, Glen Chapple, Peter